jwadi Party (SP) and Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) or the SP and Congress, have failed to deliver. The cornerstone of the BJP's grand success in the previous two Lok Sabha polls was the sweep in India's most politically significant state. Opposition unity will have no meaning if they can't stop the BJP's march in UP.

Similarly, in Karnataka, the only state in the south where the BJP has been able to form a government, the 2019 Lok Sabha election was a one-sided affair, with the party cornering 25 of the 28 seats. The state is heading for assembly polls next year. While the current BJP state government is beset with anti-incumbency, the Congress, depleted by internal feuds and mass defections, is yet to set its house in order.

Even bigger challenges lie in another 100 seats in six states—Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Rajasthan, Gujarat, MP and Chhattisgarh. The Congress and BJP are in direct contest here. The BJP won 97 seats in 2019, leaving only three for its rival. If the Congress cannot reverse its fortunes here in 2024, even talk of a post-poll coalition will lose meaning. With the emergence of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in states like Gujarat, the contest will be triangular, with both Congress and AAP eyeing the non-BJP vote. With AAP and Congress engaged in a bitter war of words in Delhi, Punjab and Gujarat, chances of their coming together too are slim.

These are the creases the opposition parties must iron out on the ground—and not just during photo-ops—if they are serious about putting up a united front against the BJP in 2024. The strength of a post-poll coalition will be determined by their ability to get the pre-poll electoral arithmetic right. This has been the Achilles heel of opposition parties in the past. Do they have it in them? ■

TAMIL NADU

SOUTHERN STIRRINGS

By Amarnath K. Menon



PTI

FEDERAL FEUD
Tamil Nadu CM M.K. Stalin with Governor R.N. Ravi

A fresh round in the fight for federalism is unfolding in Tamil Nadu, with the control over its universities emerging as the apple of discord. On August 30—in a first—the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) government called the vice-chancellors of all 22 state-run universities for a conference in Chennai. Governor R.N. Ravi—who also serves as the ex officio chancellor of these universities—was conveniently left out of the list of invitees.

Chief minister M.K. Stalin, speaking at the conference, asserted that the universities "must abide by the policy decisions of the state government", and the V-Cs "should act accordingly". Just about five months back, on April 25, the state legislature had adopted two bills that sought to empower the government to appoint the V-Cs, thereby curtailing the governor's powers. At present, the governor makes the selection from a panel of three names that are recommended by an expert committee.

The governor, as expected, is still to clear the bills, and in the meantime is actively conducting meetings with the V-Cs to push for the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, yet another sore point between the Stalin government and the Centre. The CM clearly looked sore when he recalled the two bills while speaking at the conference. "It [the appointment of V-Cs] is to do with the rights of the state government... elected by the people," he said, while claiming the bills were based on the recommendations of the Punchhi Commission on Centre-State Relations (2007-10).